

LEVEL UP

Neighborhood Sports App

Developer Briefing Document

Prepared: April 2026
Based on 277-response user survey
Confidential — Not for distribution

1. Product Vision

Level Up is a mobile app for recreational competitive sports players in Israel. It solves three core problems that 277 surveyed players confirmed: they cannot track their real improvement, they cannot find same-level players, and they have no digital identity for their sports life outside of WhatsApp groups.

The product gives every neighborhood athlete a real player card — like a FIFA card — built from actual game data. The card is their sports identity, their motivation to keep playing, and their social currency to share.

One-line pitch
"A real-time player rating, card, and matchmaking system for public court athletes in Israel."

2. Survey Findings (277 respondents)

The product direction is entirely data-driven. Key findings from the survey:

Metric	Finding
Respondents	277 total

Gender	93% male, 7% female
Age	19-25: 29%, 26-35: 29%, 36-45: 23%, 46+: 17%
Region	Tel Aviv & Center: 48%, Sharon: 21%, Haifa & North: 13%, South: 10%, Jerusalem: 7%
Play frequency	86% play once a week or more
Top sports	Basketball (126), Tennis (124), Football (43), Padel (42)
App install intent	75% rated 4-5 out of 5
Would pay	20% one-time AI analysis, 12% monthly subscription, 58% free only

Top pain points (multi-select)

Pain Point	Count
Want precise stats after a game	154
Can't find same-level players	133
Want a level-up feeling (like a video game)	132
Want highlights video	122
Want a real ranking vs others in the city	78

What information is missing to go play at a public court

Missing Info	Count
How crowded is it right now?	180
Field condition (grass, nets, lights)	112
Are the lights on right now?	100
Exact opening hours	93

Post-game data importance (1–5 average)

Data Type	Avg Score
Specific stats (speed, distance, shots)	3.22 / 5
Personal overall score (rating)	3.02 / 5
Highlights videos	2.61 / 5
Social recognition / awards	1.85 / 5

3. Core Features (MVP)

3.1 The Player Card

The player card is the central product element. Every user has one card that represents their sports identity. It works exactly like a FIFA Ultimate Team card — dark background, tier color, photo, big OVR number, and 3 key stats.

Card anatomy

Element	Description
Player photo	User uploads during onboarding. Circular frame with tier-colored glowing ring border.
Tier badge	Text pill at top: Bronze / Silver / Gold / Elite / Legend
Overall number (OVR)	Large dominant number (e.g. 83). The entire identity. 40–99 scale.
3 stat lines	Sport-specific: e.g. G/Game, Assists, Games Played for football
Location rank line	Small text: e.g. 'Tel Aviv · #3 Striker'
Corner decorations	Thin corner brackets matching tier color. Premium collectible feel.
Shine effect	Subtle light sweep on hover/tilt. Makes card feel physical.

Tier system

Tier	Overall Range	Visual	How to Unlock
Bronze	50 – 69	Dark brown card, copper border	Default on placement
Silver	70 – 79	Dark blue card, steel border	Reach OVR 70
Gold	80 – 89	Dark card, gold border + pulse ring	Reach OVR 80
Elite	90 – 94	Dark card, purple border + pulse ring	Reach OVR 90
Legend	95 – 99	Black card, orange border + sparks + animation	Top 1% nationally

Design principle

The card must feel like a collectible, not a dashboard. Dark background is non-negotiable. People should want to screenshot and share it. If it looks like a UI screen, it has failed.

The OVR number is the biggest element on the card — it IS the identity.

Minimum display number is 50. Never show anything lower — it kills motivation.

Two card variants

- **Career card:** Persistent card showing lifetime stats and current overall. Lives on the user's profile. Shareable at any time.
- **Game card:** Generated after every game. Shows tonight's stats + OVR delta (e.g. +4 OVR). This is the primary sharing trigger — the emotional peak moment.

3.2 Rating Algorithm

The overall number is calculated using a modified ELO system with additional multipliers. The formula is hidden from users — they only ever see the final OVR number.

Base ELO formula

$$\text{New rating} = \text{Old rating} + K \times (\text{Actual result} - \text{Expected result})$$

Parameter	Value / Logic
K-factor (new player, <20 games)	40 — fast early movement to find true level
K-factor (established, 20+ games)	20 — stable, harder to swing
K-factor (placement games)	60 — first 5 games move fast to calibrate
Expected result	Calculated from average rating gap between two teams
Win = 1, Draw = 0.5, Loss = 0	Standard ELO outcome values

Three multipliers on top of ELO

- **Performance multiplier:** Individual stat performance adjusts the swing. Standout on losing team = reduced loss. Poor game on winning team = reduced gain. Critical for retention — players quit systems that blame them for bad teammates.
- **Recency weight:** Inactive players (6+ weeks) drift toward mean. Prevents stale ratings and ensures fair matching when returning.
- **Confidence score (invisible):** Tracks reliability of rating based on games played. New players get conservatively matched until confidence is high.

OVR normalization

Raw ELO is mapped to a 40–99 display scale. Median player lands around 72. The mapping is non-linear — the top end (90+) is intentionally compressed to make Elite/Legend rare and aspirational.

Critical rule

Never show the formula or raw ELO to users. The mystery is part of the motivation.

Never display a number below 50. The psychological floor matters for retention.

Never let users self-report their skill level — self-reporting always inflates. The system assigns the rating.

Placement mode

New users go through 5 placement games with $K=60$. The app presents this as a ritual: 'You are unranked. Play 5 games to earn your first card.' After game 5, a card reveal animation plays and their OVR is assigned. This creates expectation that the number means something.

3.3 Matchmaking

There are two distinct matchmaking modes. These are different UX flows with different matching logic. Do not conflate them.

Mode 1 — Pickup (right now)

User wants to play immediately. Friction is time + location, not skill.

- Show which courts are active right now (crowdedness signal)
- Players check in when they arrive at a court
- Show a live 'Join this game' button when a court has active players
- Matching is opportunistic — whoever is there
- First version: manual check-in. Later: GPS auto check-in on arrival

Mode 2 — Arranged game (this week)

User wants to organize a proper game with skill-matched opponents.

- Skill band matching: ± 10 OVR points = good match range
- Show mutual WhatsApp/social connections first — social proof converts much faster than cold strangers
- 'I am free tonight 7–9pm' availability status — expires automatically after the time window
- Auto-generates a sharable game invite for WhatsApp groups

Key insight from survey

152 of 277 people use WhatsApp groups to organize games.

The app does not replace WhatsApp — it plugs into it.

Every matchmaking output should be shareable directly to WhatsApp as a formatted message or card.

3.4 Court Info (field status)

180 of 277 respondents said 'how crowded is it right now?' is the information most missing before they leave home to play. This is a high-value, low-complexity feature for MVP.

- Court database: all public courts in Israel with name, location, sport type, opening hours
- Real-time occupancy: player check-ins feed a live 'quiet / moderate / busy' indicator
- Light status: boolean field — are the lights on right now? (manual toggle or scheduled)
- Court condition: crowdsourced quality flags (net broken, grass worn, etc.)
- Future: IoT sensor integration for automatic occupancy detection

3.5 Collectibles System

Players earn collectibles purely by playing. Nothing can be bought. Everything commemorates a real moment or achievement. Three types of collectibles for MVP:

Type 1 — Field stamps

Every public court has a unique stamp. Play there = earn the stamp. Think Foursquare meets Panini.

- Stamps are designed per court — unique art for HaYarkon Park, Ramat Gan, etc.
- Milestone badges: play at 5 courts = 'Explorer', 10 courts = 'City Hopper', all Tel Aviv courts = 'TLV Legend'
- Side effect: incentivizes users to try new courts, spreading the app geographically

Type 2 — Moment cards

Specific achievements frozen in time with a date and location stamp. Cannot be grinded — they either happened or they didn't.

- 'First win ever' — date stamped, court stamped, permanent
- 'Comeback king' — won after being 3+ points down
- 'Hat trick' — 3 goals in one game (football)
- 'Perfect set' — won a set without dropping a point (tennis/padel)
- 'Giant killer' — beat an opponent rated 15+ OVR higher than you

Type 3 — Season trophies

Every calendar month ends with a trophy awarded based on your ranking at that exact moment. The trophy is permanent — even if your rank drops the next month, you keep it as historical proof of your peak.

- Monthly trophies: Gold / Silver / Bronze trophy per sport per region

- Special trophies: '#1 in Tel Aviv, March 2026' — these create urgency because they expire at month end
- Display: trophies shown on profile page in chronological shelf view

Why collectibles work

Field stamps answer: why would I go to a new court?

Moment cards answer: why would I remember and re-open the app?

Season trophies answer: why would I play hard this month specifically?

3.6 Tier Upgrade Experience

When a player's OVR crosses a tier threshold (70, 80, 90, 95), a ceremonial upgrade animation plays. This is one of the highest-value moments in the product — treat it like a level-up in a AAA game.

- OVR counter ticks up in real time after a game result is submitted
- On threshold crossing: screen flashes in tier color, card design morphs from old tier to new
- New card design reveals with a slow-burn animation — new border color, new background, new ring effect
- Auto-generated shareable screenshot: 'I just hit Gold — OVR 80' game card
- Push notification if app is in background: 'You hit Gold. Your card has been upgraded.'

4. Milestone & Progression Map

Every milestone should be visible to the user at all times on their home screen. The progress bar toward the next milestone is one of the strongest retention mechanics in the product.

Milestone	Trigger	Reward
Complete placement (5 games)	5 games played	First card reveal animation + OVR assigned
Reach Silver	OVR hits 70	Silver card design unlocked + upgrade animation
Reach Gold	OVR hits 80	Gold card + pulse ring + shareable post
Reach Elite	OVR hits 90	Purple card + animated ring
Reach Legend	OVR hits 95	Black card + spark animation + national ranking badge

Win streak x7	7 consecutive wins	Flame border effect on card (lasts 14 days)
Top 10 in city	Leaderboard position	Crown badge on card (permanent)
100 games played	Games counter	Veteran stamp + card serial number
Play at 5 courts	Field stamps	City Explorer badge
First win	Win counter	'First Win' moment card
Giant killer	Beat player 15+ OVR higher	Giant Killer moment card
Season #1	Month-end ranking	Gold trophy for that month/sport/region

5. Monetization Strategy

58% of respondents want the app free. The strategy is freemium — core experience is always free, premium unlocks are cosmetic or analytical. No pay-to-win mechanics. No randomized loot.

Free tier (always)

- Player card with OVR and basic stats
- ELO-based rating and placement
- Court finder and check-in
- Pickup matchmaking
- Field stamps and moment cards
- Monthly season trophies

Premium tier (paid)

- **One-time AI analysis:** Deep performance breakdown: pace analysis, shot patterns, weak areas, personalized training tips. 20% of respondents said they would pay for this.
- **Monthly subscription:** Ongoing AI analytics, full stat history, advanced leaderboard filters, premium card visual themes. 12% said they would pay monthly.
- **Exclusive card designs:** Seasonal card art, special edition borders, animated backgrounds — purely cosmetic, never affects OVR or ranking.

Monetization rule

The free experience must be genuinely great — not a crippled demo.

Premium is about depth and aesthetics, never about competitive advantage.

Never let premium users have a higher OVR ceiling or better matchmaking.

6. Technical Considerations

These are product-level requirements for the developer to scope. Stack decisions are the developer's call.

Data model (key entities)

- User: id, name, photo, sport(s), region, OVR, ELO, tier, games_played, created_at
- Game: id, court_id, date, sport, team_a[], team_b[], score_a, score_b, status
- PlayerGameStat: game_id, user_id, sport-specific stats, OVR_before, OVR_after, delta
- Court: id, name, location (lat/lng), sport[], lights, opening_hours, condition_flags
- CourtCheckIn: court_id, user_id, timestamp, active (bool)
- FieldStamp: court_id, user_id, earned_at
- MomentCard: user_id, type, game_id, court_id, earned_at
- SeasonTrophy: user_id, sport, region, rank, month, year

Real-time requirements

- Court occupancy: live count of checked-in players per court — WebSocket or polling every 60s
- Game result submission: one player submits, other confirms — simple challenge/accept flow
- OVR update: should feel instant after game confirmation — async is fine but UI should animate immediately

Card sharing

- Cards rendered as images server-side (or client-side canvas) for WhatsApp/Instagram sharing
- Share output: PNG image, 1080x1080 for stories, 1080x566 for feed
- Game card auto-generates after every game result is confirmed

Sport-specific stat schemas

Sport	Stats to track
Football	Goals, assists, games played, win%, goals per game
Basketball	Points, assists, steals, shot%, games played
Tennis	1st serve %, aces per game, win%, games played
Padel	Win%, kills per set, games played

7. MVP Scope Recommendation

Ship the smallest thing that delivers the core loop: play a game → get a card → share it. Everything else is phase 2.

Phase 1 — MVP (ship first)

- User onboarding: name, photo, sport selection, region
- 5-game placement mode → first card reveal
- Manual game result submission (one player submits, opponent confirms)
- ELO calculation + OVR generation after each game
- Career card with photo, OVR, 3 stats, tier design
- Game card auto-generated after each result
- Card share to WhatsApp/Instagram (PNG export)
- Tier upgrade animation on OVR threshold crossing
- Basic court finder: name, location, sport type on a map
- Court check-in for occupancy signal
- City leaderboard (per sport)

Phase 2 — Post-launch

- Field stamps and collectibles system
- Moment cards (auto-detected from game data)
- Season trophies (monthly run)
- Arranged game matchmaking (skill-based, availability status)
- Court lights / condition crowdsourced data
- AI performance analysis (monetized feature)
- Rival badges

Phase 3 — Scale

- Highlights video recording and auto-clipping
- IoT court sensors for automatic occupancy
- National leaderboard and seasonal tournaments
- Premium card cosmetics and seasonal editions

The core loop to validate in Phase 1

1. User plays a game at a public court
2. Submits result in app (takes < 60 seconds)
3. OVR updates, game card generates
4. User shares card to WhatsApp group

5. Friends ask 'what app is this?' → organic growth

If this loop works, everything else is an enhancement.

8. Key Design Principles

These are non-negotiable product decisions that should guide every UX and visual choice.

- **Dark cards always:** The player card background must be dark. It is a collectible, not a UI screen. Light-mode cards look cheap.
- **OVR is king:** The overall number must be the largest, most dominant element on the card. Everything else is context.
- **Never show below 50:** The psychological floor is 50. Any player whose true ELO would map below 50 is displayed as 50 until they earn higher.
- **No self-reporting of skill:** The system assigns all ratings from actual results. Users cannot set their own level.
- **Share-first design:** Every significant moment (tier up, season rank, moment card) should produce a shareable image automatically. Never require users to screenshot manually.
- **WhatsApp is the distribution channel:** Every social feature should be framed around sharing to WhatsApp. That is where the target audience lives.
- **Progress bars everywhere:** Always show the user how far they are from the next milestone. Visible progress is the #1 retention mechanic.
- **Play to earn, never pay to win:** No collectible, card design, or OVR boost should be purchasable. Money buys aesthetics and analysis only.

Appendix — Quick Reference

Tier thresholds

Tier	OVR Range
Bronze	50 – 69
Silver	70 – 79
Gold	80 – 89
Elite	90 – 94
Legend	95 – 99

ELO K-factors

Stage	K-Factor
Placement (games 1–5)	60
Early stage (<20 games)	40
Established (20+ games)	20

Sports supported at launch

Sport	Notes
Football (soccer)	Most courts, but 3rd in survey — broad appeal
Basketball	Joint #1 in survey (126 respondents)
Tennis	Joint #1 in survey (124 respondents)
Padel	Fast-growing (42 respondents), premium demographic

End of document — Level Up Developer Brief — April 2026